

An Act

ENROLLED SENATE
BILL NO. 710

By: Seifried of the Senate

and

Caldwell (Chad) of the
House

An Act relating to teacher preparation; amending Section 1, Chapter 400, O.S.L. 2025 (70 O.S. Supp. 2025, Section 6-186.1), which relates to establishment of TeachForwardOK; allowing the Commission for Educational Quality and Accountability to select more than one applicant to receive certain monetary award if funds are sufficient; updating statutory references; updating statutory language; and declaring an emergency.

SUBJECT: Teacher preparation

BE IT ENACTED BY THE PEOPLE OF THE STATE OF OKLAHOMA:

SECTION 1. AMENDATORY Section 1, Chapter 400, O.S.L. 2025 (70 O.S. Supp. 2025, Section 6-186.1), is amended to read as follows:

Section 6-186.1. A. The Commission for Educational Quality and Accountability shall establish and maintain a two-year pilot program to be known as TeachForwardOK to provide new, high-quality pathways to enter the teaching profession and increase the number of teachers in this state's workforce.

B. Within thirty (30) days of ~~the effective date of this act~~ August 29, 2025, the Commission shall issue a request for proposals to select technical assistance providers to evaluate teacher education programs in institutions of higher education within The Oklahoma State System of Higher Education that are accredited by the

Commission pursuant to Section 6-186 of ~~Title 70 of the Oklahoma Statutes~~ this title.

C. To participate in TeachForwardOK, a teacher education program shall submit an application to the Commission in the manner and on a form prescribed by the Commission. The Commission shall establish criteria to approve applicants. Subject to the availability of funds, the Commission shall award grants to approved applicant teacher education programs. The Commission may use any gifts, grants, devises, and donations from any public or private source and monies appropriated by the Legislature for the purpose of implementing the provisions of this section. Grants shall be used as incentives to participate and to contract with a technical assistance provider selected by the Commission pursuant to subsection B of this section. The provider shall evaluate, at a minimum, the following:

1. Teacher candidate recruitment and completion;
2. Whether the teacher education program prepares teacher candidates effectively;
3. Whether the teacher education program meets workforce needs in this state; and
4. Innovative ways to recruit nontraditional teacher candidates unique to the teacher education program.

D. 1. Evaluation reports prepared by a technical assistance provider shall be electronically submitted to the approved applicant teacher education program and the Commission.

2. Within ninety (90) days of receiving the report, the teacher education program shall electronically submit a report response to the Commission detailing how the teacher education program plans to address the evaluation report's findings. The report response shall prioritize innovative approaches to provide new, high-quality pathways to enter the teaching profession and increase the number of teachers in this state's workforce including, but not limited to:

- a. developing a system for recruiting eligible teacher candidates, such as:

- (1) a pathway for high school students to become paraprofessionals,
 - (2) a pathway for paraprofessionals to become teachers, and
 - (3) a pathway for individuals with bachelor's degrees to become teachers,
- b. developing a curriculum that includes intensive on-the-job training for teacher candidates,
 - c. identifying a mastery-based evaluation system to determine when eligible teacher candidates have mastered the skills and competencies necessary for graduation from an apprenticeship program and outlining benchmarks that teacher candidates must meet as they progress through on-the-job training,
 - d. offering a schedule that enables teacher candidates to work ~~full-time~~ full-time in a public school district while participating in an apprenticeship program and allowing paraprofessionals to continue in their positions, or
 - e. providing a flexible schedule for paraprofessionals participating in an apprenticeship program to support their success in the program that will facilitate course completion and on-the-job training.

E. Subject to the availability of funding, the Commission shall review the report responses submitted pursuant to subsection D of this section and select one approved applicant teacher education program to receive Five Hundred Thousand Dollars (\$500,000.00) to enact the initiatives outlined in the program's report response. If funds are sufficient, the Commission may select more than one approved applicant teacher education program to receive a monetary award based on the report response submitted pursuant to subsection D of this section to enact the initiatives outlined in the report response.

F. By December 31, 2027, the Commission shall electronically submit a report of TeachForwardOK's findings and recommendations to the Governor, the President Pro Tempore of the Senate, and the Speaker of the House of Representatives.

G. The Commission shall promulgate rules to implement the provisions of this section.

SECTION 2. It being immediately necessary for the preservation of the public peace, health, or safety, an emergency is hereby declared to exist, by reason whereof this act shall take effect and be in full force from and after its passage and approval.

Passed the Senate the 16th day of March, 2026.

Presiding Officer of the Senate

Passed the House of Representatives the 6th day of May, 2026.

Presiding Officer of the House
of Representatives

OFFICE OF THE GOVERNOR

Received by the Office of the Governor this _____

day of _____, 20_____, at _____ o'clock _____ M.

By: _____

Approved by the Governor of the State of Oklahoma this _____

day of _____, 20_____, at _____ o'clock _____ M.

Governor of the State of Oklahoma

OFFICE OF THE SECRETARY OF STATE

Received by the Office of the Secretary of State this _____

day of _____, 20_____, at _____ o'clock _____ M.

By: _____